

GREAT RIFT VALLEY LAKES

A global hotspot for freshwater diversity

The Great Rift Valley is part of a huge set of fissures in the Earth's crust that are expanding at a rate of about $\frac{1}{4}$ in (7mm) a year and may eventually split Africa in two. The result is a sweep of low-lying land running from Jordan to Mozambique, which is flanked by some of the highest mountains in Africa. This land is dotted with lakes that include several of the oldest, largest, and deepest bodies of freshwater in the world. The rift valley splits into two branches in Kenya and Tanzania, between which lies Lake Victoria—the largest lake in Africa and the second largest freshwater lake in the world.

Fresh water, soda water

The Great Rift Valley lakes are generally stretched along the vertical axis of the rift. They differ widely in character, ranging from large, deep, and freshwater—like Malawi (also known as Nyasa), Tanganyika, and Turkana—to

shallow and intensely mineralized and alkaline in the so-called soda lakes. Having been isolated from each other for millions of years, each lake has its own unique collection of aquatic animals. The deep waters of Lake Malawi, for example, which encompass a wide variety of habitats, are home to as many as 3,000 species of fish—more than any other lake in the world. The Great Rift Valley lakes also support large numbers of land-based animals and birds, such as pelicans and waders. The soda lakes—Natron, Bogoria, Nakuru, and Elementalia—are famous for their huge flocks of lesser flamingos.

